



Ecstatic colonists tear down a statue of King George III in New York in celebration of the signing of the Declaration of Independence.

“WE HOLD THESE TRUTHS TO BE SELF-EVIDENT, THAT ALL MEN ARE **CREATED EQUAL**, THAT THEY ARE ENDOWED BY THEIR CREATOR WITH CERTAIN **UNALIENABLE RIGHTS**, THAT AMONG THESE ARE **LIFE, LIBERTY AND THE PURSUIT OF HAPPINESS.**”

US Declaration of Independence, July 4, 1776

AS THE AMERICAN REVOLUTIONARY WAR WAS GAINING MOMENTUM, on July 4 the **First Continental Congress** issued a **Declaration of Independence**, formally announcing the separation of the North American colonies from British rule and calling this collective the **United States**. The document outlined reasons for the decision to separate from Britain while asserting certain natural rights. The ideas put forth in this declaration—that all men were created equal and had the right to “life, liberty and the pursuit of happiness”—would not, however, apply to everyone. Enslaved Africans—some of whom had been fighting on the Americans’ side—were excluded.

The year 1776 also witnessed the publication of many influential works. In January, the writer and radical thinker **Thomas Paine** (see panel, opposite), who had been living only a short time in Philadelphia, issued a pamphlet entitled *Common Sense*, calling for American independence and

the establishment of a republican government. The pamphlet, initially published anonymously, was hugely influential both nationally and internationally and had a significant role in furthering the cause. In Britain, Scottish philosopher **Adam Smith** (1723–90) published *An Enquiry into the Nature and Causes of the Wealth of Nations*, which outlined the advantages of a system of free trade, changing the way politicians and the public thought about economic expansion.

Also in this year, the first volume of *The History of the Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire* by English historian **Edward Gibbon** (1737–94) was published. The work struck a chord and was a success. It was also noteworthy for Gibbon’s methodology, which was objective and meticulous in his use of reference material, making it the yardstick for future historians. A further five volumes were published over the following decade.



A colonial map of the city Colonia del Sacramento in Uruguay.

IN BAVARIA, there was unrest over the succession to the throne. Elector **Maximilian III Joseph** (1727–77), last of the Wittelsbach line, died, and **Charles Theodore** (1724–99), Elector Palatine was crowned. Charles had no legitimate heir but several bastards for whom he sought land. He signed a treaty with Joseph II of Austria to cede Lower Bavaria to Austria in exchange for part of the Austrian Netherlands. This angered Frederick II of Prussia and in 1778, the **War of the Bavarian Succession** broke out, ending in 1779.

Spain and Portugal finally settled ongoing disputes in the **Río de la Plata** region with the **First Treaty of San Ildefonso**. Spain ceded territory in the Amazon basin in return for control over the Banda Oriental (in present-day Uruguay).



Charles Theodor
The Elector Palatine, Charles Theodore, had no legitimate heirs but he had several illegitimate ones. He proved an unpopular king.



A view of the opulent interior of La Scala opera house in Milan.



Clubs used against Cook
Traditional Hawaiian clubs like these may have been used in the attack that caused James Cook's death.

WITH TWO SUCCESSFUL VOYAGES TO HIS NAME, Captain James Cook (see 1773) set out for a third in 1776, this time to search for the **Northwest Passage**, a fabled Arctic shortcut that was supposed to connect the Atlantic and Pacific Oceans. By 1778 he had made the first European contact with the **Hawaiian islands**. He continued on to the Arctic circle, but failed to find the passage. He later sailed back to Hawaii, where a dispute over a missing boat led to his being killed by Hawaiians in 1779.

In **Milan**, a grand opera house was opened—**La Scala**. It was founded under the patronage of Maria Theresa of Austria (the city was under Austrian rule) to replace a theater that had been destroyed in a fire. The new theater was built on the site of the church of Santa Maria alla Scala and financed by wealthy patrons. It opened on August 3 with a performance of *L'Europa riconosciuta*, an **opera** by Antonio Salieri (1750–1825).



A Xhosa family, from a painting by French naturalist Pierre Sonnerat.

THE RELOCATION OF THE BOERS (Dutch-speaking settlers) to remote regions hundred of miles north of Cape Town was causing problems for the **Xhosa** people. These tribes had settled in the territory long before the Boers’ arrival. Both groups were cattle farmers and competed for rich pasture land for their herds.

Attempts were made to establish a border between the **Fish and Sundays Rivers**, although both groups violated any agreement. Tension turned to violence, with the Xhosa raiding Boer cattle and murdering some herdsmen, possibly in retaliation for the death



Boer house
Dutch settlers in South Africa moved away from Cape Town, deep into rural areas where they raised livestock.

of a tribesman. The Boers then attacked and captured more than 5,000 head of cattle.

These skirmishes, amounting to the first **Xhosa War**, did not resolve the root cause of the dispute—access to grazing lands and water. Intermittent battle continued for almost a century.

February 17 **Edward Gibbon** (1737–94) publishes volume one of *The History of the Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire*

July 4 **Declaration of Independence** signed in British American colonies

October 1 **Treaty of San Ildefonso** confirms Spanish possession of Uruguay and Portuguese control of Amazon land

February 6 **France** formally enters **American Revolutionary War** against Britain

February 14 **Captain Cook** is killed on his third voyage while in the Hawaiian islands

Author and pamphleteer **Thomas Paine** (1737–1809) publishes *Common Sense*

Scottish philosopher **Adam Smith** (1723–1790) publishes *Wealth of Nations*

War of Bavarian Succession between Prussia and Austria (to 1779)

Knight v. Wedderburn case rules that slavery laws do not apply in Scotland

Xhosa Wars against British and Boer settlers (to 1879)